MODULE 2

Workflow Thinking

From understanding automation to designing how work **actually flows**.

TRIGGER → FLOW → RESULT

15 Minutes

What You Will Learn

Workflow Fundamentals

Understand what a workflow is and why workflow thinking is critical for design.

Core Building Blocks

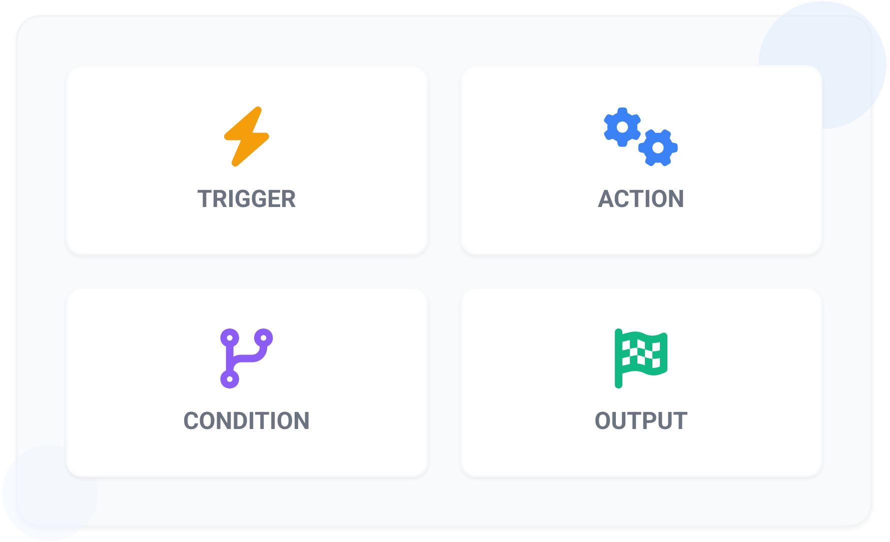
Master the main components: triggers, actions, conditions, and outputs.

Process Breakdown

Learn how to decompose complex processes into clear, sequential steps.

Applying Automation

Identify exactly where automation can be applied effectively within a flow.



SECTION 2: WORKFLOW THINKING

What is a Workflow?

DEFINITION

A **workflow** is a structured sequence of steps used to complete a task or process. It shows how work moves from a starting point to an end result.

Why Workflows Matter

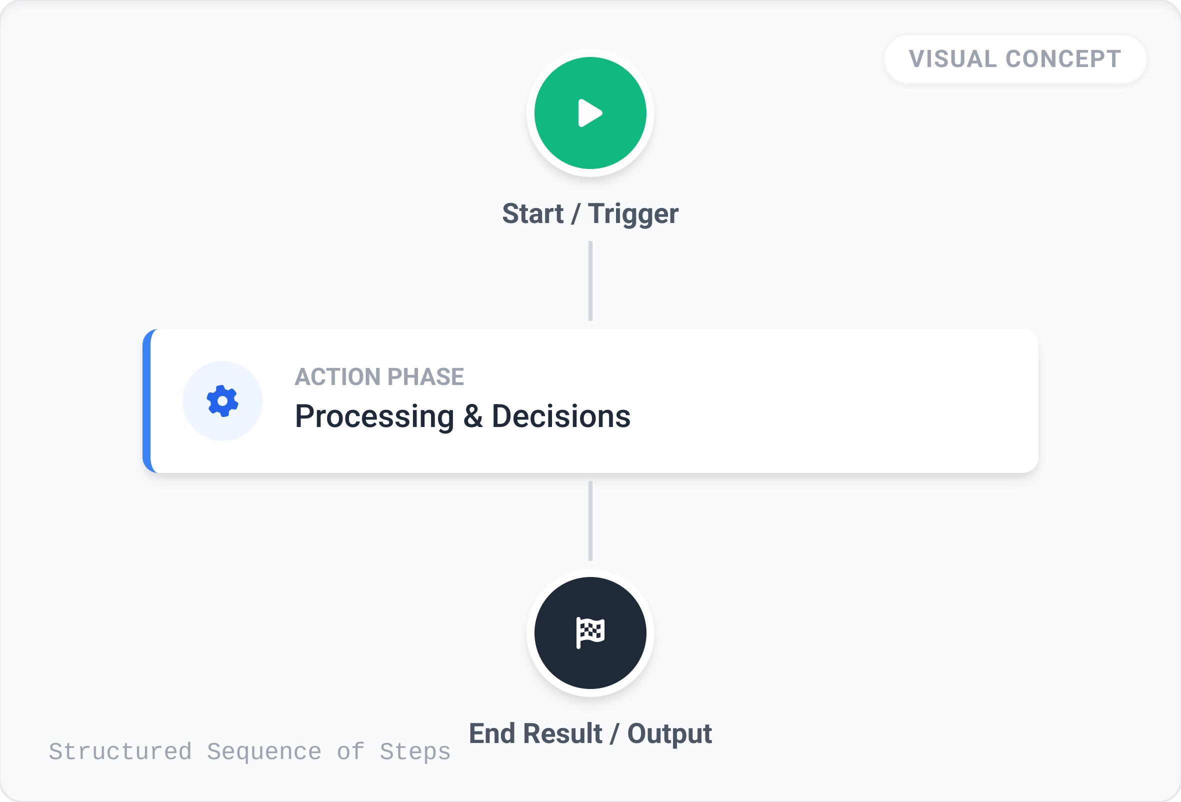
- ✓ Understand how work is currently done
- ✓ Identify inefficiencies and delays
- ✓ Standardize processes for consistency
- ✓ Find opportunities for automation

Everyday Examples

Form: Submitted → Reviewed → Approved

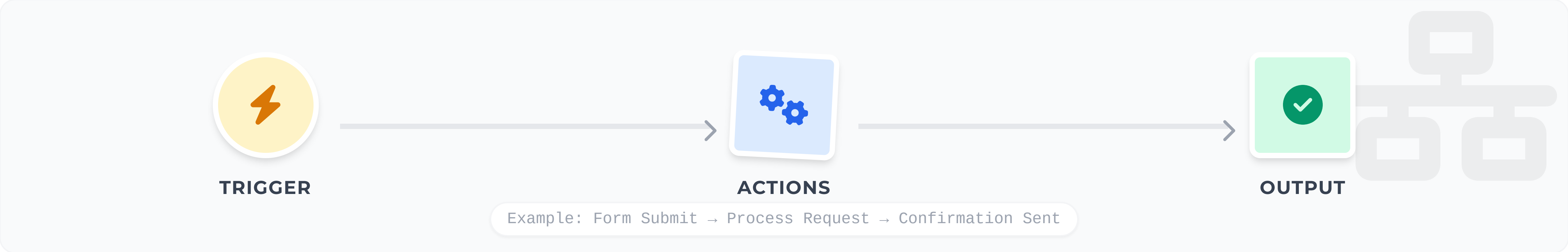
Booking: Made → Confirmation Sent → Reminder Issued

"A workflow is the full journey, not just a single task."



The Core Structure: Trigger → Actions → Output

Most workflows can be explained using this simple three-part model.



A Trigger

The event that starts the workflow. No workflow starts randomly; there is always a signal.

Examples:
- Form submitted
- File uploaded
- Deadline reached

B Actions

The steps that happen after the trigger. This is what the workflow actually *does*.

Examples:
- Send email
- Update database
- Assign task

C Output

The result of the workflow. Every process should end with a visible outcome.

Examples:
- Notification sent
- Report generated
- Alert created

Conditions and Decision Points

WORKFLOW LOGIC

What is a Condition?

THE "CHECK" STEP

- A **decision point** that evaluates criteria.
- Checks whether a statement is **True or False**.
- Determines which path the workflow takes next.

KEY DISTINCTION

Action = DOING | Condition = **CHECKING**

Why Conditions Matter

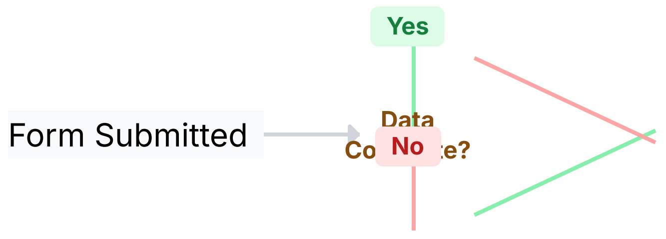
INTELLIGENCE & FLEXIBILITY

- Makes workflows **intelligent** rather than just linear.
- Allows handling of **exceptions** and edge cases.
- Ensures the right response for every situation.

REAL-WORLD LOGIC

```
IF request is urgent THEN send SMS
ELSE send Email
```

DECISION LOGIC EXAMPLE



Key Message: Conditions help workflows make decisions and choose the right path.

Workflow Thinking as a Design Mindset

Analyze the Flow

Ask: What starts this? What happens next? Who is involved?

Identify Friction

Spot where delays happen, where errors occur, and where work gets stuck.

Assess Suitability

Distinguish between repetitive tasks and those needing human judgment.

Ensure Connection

Avoid disconnected tools. Build automation that is structured and scalable.

Find Opportunities

Look for bottlenecks, handoffs, waiting times, and duplicate data entry.

💡 "Workflow thinking means seeing work as a **system of connected steps**, not isolated activities."

METHOD WORKFLOW DESIGN

How to Break Down a Process

> A useful approach is to **break any process into small steps** before attempting to automate it.

THE 5-STEP METHOD

1. **Identify Start** — What event triggers the process?
2. **List Actions** — What steps happen next?
3. **Find Decisions** — Are there conditions or approvals?
4. **Define Output** — What is the final result?
5. **Automate** — Spot repetitive & manual parts.

GENERIC EXAMPLE: HANDLING A REQUEST

TRIGGER: Request Submitted → ACTIONS: Log & Review → DECISION: Urgent? → ACTION: Assign Team → OUTPUT: **Request Routed**

Key Message: Breaking down a process into steps makes automation easier to design and implement.

Suggested time: 2 min

SUMMARY

Section Recap

Flow Defined.

Ready for Automation.

A Connected Sequence

A workflow is not just a task; it's the full journey of how work moves through structured steps from **start to finish**.

Trigger, Actions, Output

Every workflow begins with a **trigger**, processes through **actions** and decision points (conditions), and produces a clear **output**.

Workflow Thinking Mindset

Designing automation requires seeing work as a system to identify inefficiencies, dependencies, and the best opportunities for **intelligent automation**.

COMING UP

AI Agents & Intelligent Automation

In the next section, we will explore how intelligent systems do more than just follow steps—they **interpret**, **interact**, and **decide**.

PREVIEW: THE ROLE OF AN AI AGENT

Interpret
Understand complex information

→

Interact
Use external tools & APIs

→

Decide
Support decision-making